



What is a grass?

Grasses are short plants with long, narrow leaves, jointed stems, and flowers that are almost always arranged in spikes. This group of plants first appeared on land more than 66 million years ago, evolving over time into the 12,000 species of grasses today. Grasses cover huge areas of land on every continent and are more widely spread than any other type of plant.



Grass flowers

Meadow foxtail flower



Anthers poke out of the flowers and bob in the wind, releasing pollen grains.

Grasses produce flower spikes with many small flowers, which are wind-pollinated. As they mature, each flower dangles its anthers in the wind, allowing millions of pollen grains to be blown away to fertilize the feathery, sticky stigmas of another grass. Since grasses do not have to attract animal pollinators, their flowers have lost their colorful petals.

Growing point ➤ Grasses can survive continual grazing by wild and farm animals because their growing point is at the base of their stem, close to the soil. When nibbling animals eat the leaves, they leave this growing point intact, allowing the plant to regrow easily.